

TENNESSEE OWNER-BUILDER PERMIT KIT

Find your status · File what applies either way · Build to the 2018 IRC

Project Address: _____

City / Town: _____

County: _____

Jurisdiction Status: _____

Owner-Builder: _____

Permit Application Date: _____

Jurisdiction status is EXEMPT, SRBP or OPT OUT.

Look up your CITY first, then the county — TN.1 shows you how.

Every Tennessee statute, rule and requirement in this kit
is cited on the page it appears on — verified September 2026.

BUILD YOUR HOUSE

build-your-house.com

First Edition — 2026

How to Use This Kit

Five working documents, from "which of three regimes am I in?" to the last inspection.

Tennessee has **one** state residential building code and **three** different answers to who enforces it. The State Fire Marshal's Office publishes the answer for every jurisdiction in the state, and tags each one with a label: **EXEMPT**, **SRBP**, or **OPT OUT**.

EXEMPT means the local government runs its own building department and enforces its own adopted code. **SRBP** means the State Residential Building Program applies — you buy a state permit and state contract inspectors come out. **OPT OUT** means the jurisdiction passed a resolution and *no residential building code is enforced there at all*. Fifty counties are EXEMPT, eight are SRBP, and thirty-seven have opted out.

Two things about that map catch almost everybody. **The unit is the jurisdiction, not the county** — a county's resolution reaches only its unincorporated area, so a city inside an opted-out county frequently has its own building department. And **an opt-out is not permanent**: it expires 180 days after that legislative body's next election unless the new body passes it again.

WHAT IS IN THE KIT

The five documents

	Document	What it does for you
TN.1	Owner-Builder Exemption Walkthrough	How to find your jurisdiction's status in about five minutes, the licensing exemption for building your own home, and what you may do yourself trade by trade. Read this first.
TN.2	Permit Application Checklist	What to gather before you file — the code editions actually in force, the state fee schedule and how your fee is computed, and the approvals that apply no matter which regime you are in.
TN.3	Inspection Sequence	The inspections the state rule requires, in the order the rule fixes them, the separate electrical track that runs alongside them, and fields for dates and results.
TN.4	Where to File Directory	Which office handles your parcel under each of the three statuses, the offices that exist regardless, and a page to record every one you confirmed.
TN.5	Forms & Documents Index	Each document you will meet: what it is, when, and from where — plus what needs no permit at all.

HOW TO USE IT

- **Start with TN.1.** Its first section settles which of the three statuses governs your parcel. Nothing else in the kit sequences correctly until you know that answer, and the answer is published — you do not have to guess at it.

- **Buy the electrical permit regardless.** This is the single most expensive mistake in Tennessee. The state electrical program rests on a different chapter of the code from the building program, and opting out of the building code does not touch it. Every one of the thirty-seven opt-out counties is still inside the State Electrical Program.
- **Then deal with the septic system.** On a rural Tennessee build the subsurface sewage disposal permit is the longest pole, and the state building permit rule will ask you to certify you have it.
- **Keep TN.3 on the job** and record every inspection as it happens — most of all if you are in an opt-out county where nobody is required to inspect you. It is the only evidence you will have when you sell, refinance or insure.

How these facts were checked — and what this is not

Every Tennessee claim here was read against its primary source in September 2026 — the Secretary of State's official rule chapters, the Tennessee Code, and the State Fire Marshal's own published program pages — and is cited where it appears. Where the answer genuinely depends on your city or county, the kit says so and gives you a line to write down what you confirmed. Not legal advice.